

Since much of the research and subsequent design changes hinge on this archetypal fictional character, *how* the persona is created is very important. In this case, the last thing “fictional” means is off the top of your head. It’s quite the opposite, since the persona has to represent all the different people who will eventually use your product or service. Therefore, each characteristic and trait of your persona depends crucially on the actual end users, and as such must be fiction based on fact.

So yeah, a persona is a detailed fictional character, whose *raison d’être* is effectively modelling and communicating observations from research on a group of people. This will enable you, the designer, to focus on one person instead of the thousands of users that the persona represents. This will prevent you from being overwhelmed by the notion of designing for the eventual swarm of users. Personas are great for this very reason as they convert this generic “everybody” into specific “somebodies”. Our brains are wired to think in terms of people, and giving a face to the homogenous masses utilises this heuristic to its fullest. It builds empathy for the end users. Moreover, the whole market can be accounted for with a few personas, which are definitely more manageable.

Personas also help keep the whole team on the same page, as they’re the antithesis of ambiguous “end users”. They help build focus on the key audience segments. By being specific, they ensure consensus on important aspects and make disparities in views apparent. So, they greatly reduce communication gaps and ideative dissonance between functionally different roles further down the product pipeline. Further, besides streamlining additional features and ideas, they also help measure effectiveness of designs. Best of all, they inherently promote and provoke discussion about end users, ensuring a deeper understanding of the audience. They’re much



Fill in the person